

Lava's second act

Challenging global giants in India's budget 5G segment

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For years now, we have seen the Indian smartphone market being dominated by foreign brands like Xiaomi, Realme, Vivo, Samsung, Motorola, and the likes. This is especially true in the budget segment, where price often decides the winner. But now, homegrown brands, such as Lava, are hoping to find a spot for themselves in the crowded market and are betting big on affordable 5G smartphones.

In an exclusive conversation with Digit, Sumit Singh, Product Head at Lava International Limited, spoke about the company's renewed strategy. Lava is not just playing catch-up anymore. Instead, it is trying to make a space of its own in entry level and budget segments.

From survival to scale

Lava has had its ups and downs. Once seen as a challenger to global players, the brand almost faded into the background as foreign competitors flooded the market with aggressive pricing and flashy specs. Singh admits that the last few years have been about survival, keeping the brand relevant and alive in a market where dozens of local players couldn't keep up.

But now, in 2025, that has changed. Lava is moving from survival to scale. The company is focusing on performance-driven phones with practical features rather than chasing spec-sheet gimmicks. Singh explains, "We understand that the Indian consumer

wants value that lasts; reliable performance, a battery that doesn't give up, and after-sales support they can count on. That's where Lava is investing its energy."

We even got in touch with Tarun Pathak, Research Director at Counterpoint Research. He added, "Lava is regaining share in Indian smartphone market and was the fastest (156%) growing brand YoY in sub 10K and second fastest (96%) growing brand in the overall smartphone market in Q2 2025 as per Counterpoint Research. One of the key reasons for the growth was aggressive portfolio in sub 20K especially the Blaze, Storm and Agni series by bringing fast charging, AMOLED display at competitive price points."

Standing out

The challenge, of course, is clear. The budget 5G segment in India is one of the hottest contested spaces, dominated by brands such as Motorola, Vivo, and iQOO, all of whom have set the bar with aggressive pricing and spec-heavy offerings. For a brand like Lava, which is attempting to make a comeback, cutting through this clutter is not really a small task.

Singh tells us, "Our focus is on three things: India-first design and support, performance over hype, and building trust with our customers. These are

areas where we believe we can win because they matter to Indian users."

On the India-first front, Lava is doubling down on its "Made in India" positioning. Manufacturing, R&D, and design are increasingly being handled domestically. "It's not just about assembling phones here.

We're designing with Indian consumers in mind; their habits, their challenges, their expectations," Singh adds.

Then comes the performance factor. Singh points out that many budget devices boast features that sound impressive on paper but are rarely used. "How many people really use a 200MP camera every day?" he asks rhetorically. "Instead, what most people want is a phone

that doesn't lag after six months, a battery that lasts through the day, and software that isn't bloated."

The third pillar is the trust factor, and here Singh believes Lava has an opening. Lava is positioning itself as a transparent, reliable alternative. "When you buy a Lava phone, you know who's making it and where. If something goes wrong, we have a service network that is responsive," he says.

They have used this philosophy with their latest mid-range bet, the Lava Shark series. Singh describes it as a product designed mainly with young Indian users in mind, particularly gamers and streamers who push their phones to the limit. "The Storm Shark is built to handle sustained heavy use. We've worked hard on thermal management so it doesn't overheat during long gaming sessions."

In his words, this is what sets Lava apart in what he calls a "sea of copy-paste devices." ■



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